Sara Aref-Zahed ✉ sara.aref-zahed@wifo.ac.at

POSITION

2023 – present	**Research Staff** Research Group: **Climate, Environmental and Resource Economics** Project Coordination with IIASA on the EU-project *Land Management for Sustainability (LAMASUS)*: developing a governance model based on collaborative among policy makers, land users, and researchers	Austrian Institute of Economic Research (WIFO), Austria

EDUCATION

2026 – 2027 *Admitted*	**MSc in Medical Anthropology** Focus**:** Environment. Supervisor: Prof. Eben Kirksey.	University of Oxford, United Kingdom
2024 – 2026	**MA in Political Science** with honors Final grade: 1.4 (Austrian scale: 1 = best possible grade, 5 = fail). Thesis: *The Birth of Eco-Biopolitics: Bringing More-than-human Life into Governance*. Supervisor: Sergej Seitz, PhD.	University of Vienna, Austria
2023 – 2026	**MSc in Conservation Biology and Biodiversity Management** with honors Final grade: 1.4 (Austrian scale)**.** Thesis: *Dynamics of Reappearance of Nearly Extinct Anurans in a Tropical Region Highly Affected by Amphibian Declines.* Co-/Supervisor: Prof. Franz Essl; Carlos Adrían García-Rodríguez, PhD.	University of Vienna, Austria
2016 – 2023	**BA in Political Science** and **BSc in Biology**	University of Vienna, Austria

ACADEMIC SKILLS

Quantitative Methods	Regression (linear, logistic, panel, GLM); causal inference (Difference-in-Differences, quasi-experiments); time series analysis (forecasting); policy trend analysis
Qualitative Methods	Content analysis; interviews; discourse analysis; case studies
Machine Learning & Modeling	Random Forest (RF), Generalized Boosted Models (GBM), Generalized Additive Models (GAM); ensemble modeling (biomod2)
Ecological Modeling & Analysis	Species Distribution Modeling (SDM); multicollinearity analysis; COUE-framework, Niche Margin Index (NMI); model evaluation (AUC, TSS, Cohen's Kappa, Boyce)
Programming & Data Analysis	R: Data wrangling; statistical modeling; geospatial analysis; visualization
Geospatial Tools	QGIS

WORK IN PROGRESS

Peer-reviewed Journal Articles:

Aref-Zahed, S. (forthcoming) 'The Wolf as Political Symbol: Populist Style and Exclusionary Governance in Austria', *Nature and Culture*.

Aref-Zahed, S (under review) 'Eco-Biopolitics and the Governance of More-Than-Human Life: Technocratic and Relational Configurations in the EU and Ecuador', *Environment and Planning E: Nature and Space*

Aref-Zahed, S., Essl, F., Zumbado-Ulate, H., Acosta-Chaves, V.J., Chaves Cordero, G.A. & García-Rodríguez, C.A. (in preparation) 'Unexpected Returns: Reappearance Dynamics of Tropical Fogs After Regional Declines', *Diversity and Distribution*.

Editor-reviewed Book chapters:

Aref-Zahed, S. (in press) 'Sacred Hydrology as Policy: Iranian Traditions of Water Governance', in Mandal, P.K. & Topoonyanont, W.S. (eds) *The Ecospiritual Narratives: Literature, Culture, and Media*. Palgrave Macmillan.

Aref-Zahed, S. (in preparation; proposal accepted) 'Eco-biopolitics: Resurrectable life and de-extinction', in Stark, H. (ed.) *Resurrecting Species: Speculative Engagements with De-Extinction*. Publisher to be confirmed (approaching Mattering Press).

Aref-Zahed, S. (under review; proposal accepted) 'Eco-Biopolitics and the Governance of Plant Life in *The Overstory*', in Gürova, E. (ed.) *The Plant Turn: Literature, Ecology, and the Green Imagination across Periods*. Publisher to be confirmed (under strong interest by Bloomsbury Academic's Critical Plant Studies).

Aref-Zahed, S. (forthcoming) 'hamnafas (هم‌نَفَس / co-breather)', in Burke, B. & Fay-Stindt, Z. (eds) *A Lexicon for Animacy* (edited volume). Publisher to be confirmed.

SELECTED CONFERENCE/WORKSHOP TALKS

2026	*Eco-Biopolitics and the Rights of Nature.* Animal Law Workshop. Presentation accepted and scheduled for September.	University of Cambridge, UK
2026	*Eco-Biopolitics: Making Life Count.* Environmental Justice Conference. Virtual presentation.	Colorado State University, USA
2026	*Governing Life Beyond the Human: Eco-Biopolitics and the Redistribution of Agency.* Philosophy of Agency in a More-Than-Human World Workshop.	University of Santiago de Compostela, Spain
2026	*Reconfiguration of geographic ranges and climatic niches during the recovery of declined anurans in Costa Rica* (with Héctor Zumbado-Ulate, Víctor Acosta-Chaves, Gerardo Chaves, Franz Essl, & Adrián García-Rodríguez). XIII Latin American Congress of Herpetology, presented by A. García-Rodríguez.	Costa Rica
2025	*Large Predators as Political Symbols: Right-Wing Populism and the Debate over Rewilding in Central and Western Europe.* Rethinking Wild Europe Conference.	University of Vienna, Austria
2025	*Modellierung von Wolfslebensräumen: Naturschutzpotenziale* (Modeling Wolf Habitats: Conservation Potential in Austria). Biodiversity Congress.	BOKU University, Austria
2025	*Assessing the Effectiveness of Price Observation Policies on Food Inflation in Europe: A Difference-in-Differences Approach* (with Franz Sinabell & Anna Renhart). 19th International European Forum on System Dynamics and Innovation in Food Networks.	Germany

INVITED GUEST LECTURES

2025	*Wolf Habitat Modeling in Austria*. UNESCO Chair: Sustainable Management of Conservation Areas (virtual).	Austria
2025	*Wolf politics in Austria* in the course *"The Alps: Heights (and Depths) of Modernity"* (taught by Associate Prof. Seth Peabody) (virtual).	Carleton College, USA

SUMMER SCHOOLS

2025	Visegrad Environmental Philosophy Summer School on Water (VEPSS)	University of Wrocław, Poland

GRANTS

2026 Philosophy of Agency in a More-Than-Human World Workshop Grant, 250€

2025 Erasmus+ Blended Intensive Program Grant for participation in the VEPSS, 838€.

ORGANIZATION OF WORKSHOPS

2026	LAMASUS: 4th Stakeholder-Board Workshop.	Belgium
2026	Austrian Case-Study Roadshow.	Austria

LANGUAGES

Gilaki: native
Farsi: native
German: native

English: C1 (IELTS Academic, band: 8)
Spanish: approx. A2
Mandarin: approx. A1

Latin: reading knowledge